SARGONIC DINNER AT KANEŠ: THE OLD ASSYRIAN SARGON LEGEND

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A very unusual literary tablet, Kt. j/k 97 from Kültepe, was published by C. Günbattı in 1997. It is inscribed with what already the first editor described as an Old Assyrian version of legends about Sargon. Since then the tablet has caused a good deal of discussion. Translations or editions have been made by M. Van De Mieroop (2000), K. Hecker (2001), B. Foster (2002, 2005), A. Cavigneaux (2005), and J. G. Dercksen (2005).[2] These studies represent extremely different approaches: Hecker takes the text at face value and reads it as a laudatory royal inscription, whereas others see it as a kind of parody of inscriptions or legends about Sargon (Van De Mieroop 2000; Foster 2002, 2005), inspired by Mario Liverani.[3] Dercksen (2005: 108) goes to the opposite extreme, stating that the "supposedly literary character of the text can be ignored, as this modern concept was alien to OA society". He sees the text as "not a parody", but instead as having "functioned to extol Sargon of Akkad during *kispum* celebrations that were part of the official cult of Assur". Cavigneaux's study suggests a middle way between these extremes.

The tablet was found — and probably written — in Anatolia within the community of Assyrian merchants living abroad in Kaneš, on a tablet that looks very much like a normal business letter. It was excavated in 1958 in the house of Aḫ-šalim, an ordinary merchant, from whose house a number of other texts have been published.[4] It alludes to the legend *Sargon King of Battle*, in which, following M. Liverani (1993: 52–6), Cavigneaux understands an expedition of Sargon to Anatolia, aided by the merchants of Purušḫaddum, as in fact referring to the Old Assyrian colonization in Anatolia. Cavigneaux further suggests what kind of situation lies behind our text (2005: 596): "Le nouveau texte ... suggère de manière très concrète que les marchands assyriens berçaient leurs soirées au coin de la cheminée, au long des hivers anatoliens, d'histoires dont les rois d'Akkad étaient les héros". He sees the text as an *unicum*, with hardly any chances of ever finding a duplicate (p. 597).

Cavigneaux's interpretation is a significant alternative to Foster's, who attempts to explain it by means of elaborate wordplays and allusions to an Assyrian legend about Sargon now lost, as well as to political and ethnic jokes no longer fully understandable (Foster 2005: 71).[5] Unfortunately, Foster's statement that "this composition bears witness to a sophisticated Assyrian literary tradition awaiting discovery" (p. 72) will hardly prove to be justified, as the text — if Cavigneaux is right — seems to be almost a kind of improvisation. Yet the final word has not been spoken, cf. the discussion below.

According to Cavigneaux, the scribe was familiar with Sargonic inscriptions through stelae inscribed with Sargon of Akkad and Naramsin's inscriptions, erected in the temple courtyard in

[1] Gojko Barjamovic and Aage Westenholz read a previous version of this study and are thanked for numerous critical comments, suggestions, and additions, the most important of which are incorporated marked as G.B or A.W. below. J. Goodnick Westenholz and M. Sigrist kindly made an important study of marrow and brain available before its publication. Important suggestions by J. Goodnick Westenholz are marked J.G.W. below. W. R. Mayer of the Pontifical Biblical Institute in Rome kindly made a study concerning the gazelle episode available before publication, and generously took the time to read a previous version of the manuscript and to comment on it. Important suggestions by him are marked W.R.M. below. Alster's interest in the text was aroused by the gazelle-episode (ll. 13–18), and was inspired by Cavigneaux's study (2005) to attempt a few more steps. J. S. Cooper, Dina Katz, K. Eksell and N. W. Brunn also read a previous stage of the manuscript and are thanked for useful comments and references. Jon Taylor kindly checked a number in the British Museum. Since T. Oshima had already done a good deal of work on the text it was decided to present our results as a joint publication. The responsibility for the opinions expressed here as well as for any errors rests with the authors alone.

[2] J. G. Dercksen is thanked for making his study available before publication. It includes significant new readings esp. in ll. 62–3.

[3] Cf. Van De Mieroop (2000: 155, n. 106).

[4] Other published tablets from the same archive are j/k 9, 39, 76, 107, 201, 288b, 292, 313, 623, 625, 686, cf. Michel (2003). The archive contained 764 texts.

[5] Far from all of Foster's wordplays seem convincing. Cavigneaux (2005: 599) justly questions whether puns on e.g. *šarru* "king" vs. *sarru* "liar", *nāru* "river" vs. *narû* "stele", and *ṣabītu* "gazelle" vs. *sābītu* "brasseur" were intended (cf. Foster 2005: 72 and 73, n. 1, etc. for more details).

his home city Assur.[6] These must have aroused his curiosity and historical interest (Cavigneaux 2005: 596). With some sound ironic distance he and his fellow merchants took Sargon for a model hero.

Did the scribe use a written tablet to copy from? Cavigneaux (2005: 596) suggests that the concluding statement *mīnam iṭṭuppim lušam'id*[7] "que puis-je ajouter sur la tablette?" shows that the text was conceived as "written", but it also has a very concrete meaning, in that both the obverse and the reverse, as well as the upper and lower edges, are fully inscribed, so in the end, when pressed for space, the scribe condensed what he had to say to a minimum of space in six rather long lines written on the left edge (ll. 61–6). This suggests that it is unlikely that he copied directly from a model, and unlikely that a duplicate will ever be found. The abrupt style, in fact far from the elevated style of *Sargon King of Battle*, points in the same direction, suggesting improvisations.[8] An additional observation corroborates this: the inscription itself concludes on the very last line of the reverse (l. 60) with the mention of Kaneš, which cannot be a minor coincidence, whatever its precise meaning. This could have been meant as a kind of conclusion to the whole composition, and it is notable that it is introduced in l. 59 by an expression that may well mean "by the way" or "in addition",[9] as if the scribe almost forgot it, but then remembered it as important at the last moment when running out of space. It may rather have been the pseudo-autobiographical format that caused an "I" to appear in these lines, however.

The mention here of Kaneš indeed makes it likely that the text as known to us alludes to phenomena dating from a time later than Sargon's own.[10] An alternative would be to take it at face value and consider whatever geographical locations may be mentioned, etc., as basically standing for what they meant at the time of the Akkadian dynasty of Sargon some centuries earlier. Since this is unlikely, there is a chance that phenomena from the time of the Old Assyrian colonization of Anatolia are meant as being "backdated", perhaps humorously, to the time of the Akkadian dynasty, and then it is indeed a kind of "literature". The question then becomes how seriously is it to be understood?

This study does not seek to approach the issue with any preconceived opinion in mind, but simply seeks to present at least some major points of debate as objectively as possible, listing some pros and cons in each case. Since there is consensus that ll. 19–40 describe meal procedures in Sargon's army, in a way that alludes to Sargon's famous boast that 5400 people dined daily before his face, and there is agreement about much of its literal meaning, this will be a good starting point.

Summary of the Sargon dinner and rank-order (ll. 19–40)

29. All the soldiers listed in ll. 19–28 were invited by the official mentioned in l. 29.

19–22. *irtum/irātum* "ribsteaks" or "entrecôtes"(?) from 1000 oxen and 6000 sheep were served every day for 7000 "heroes". Apparently these were considered very good meat, although not the very best.

23–4. *arkātim* "sirloin steaks" from 1000 oxen and 6000 sheep were served every day for 3000 "runners". These also seem to have been considered very good meat, perhaps even better than the "ribsteaks".

[6] J. Reade (2004) does not mention any stele from the OA period, and no such stela has been found, but stelae may have been erected according to royal decrees. The closest one can come is a copper spear-point found in Assur bearing a dedicatory inscription of a servant of Man-ištušu, VA 8300, Grayson RIME 1, p. 8; Frayne, RIME 2, p. 82 (refs. J.G.W.).

[7] Dercksen (2005: 110), however, reads 63 *i-ṭup-pè*, "on the tablets", cf. the comments below.

[8] Alster (2004: 22 n. 3) suggests that some rarely attested Sumerian compositions or so-called unica (such as the *Gudam tale* and *Ninurta and the Turtle*) can be seen as improvisations based on longer and much better attested "standard" compositions, authored by scribes who knew the standard compositions well, but in a humorous mood took the liberty to retell them in new ways. The situation would then be not exactly identical, but similar. Cf. also George (2003: 18), who suggests that young scribes, tired of the classical Sumerian curriculum "may even have improvised lines in Akkadian for the fun of it".

[9] Cf. the comments on ll. 59–60 below.

[10] Kaneš did in fact exist in the Old Akkadian period, see Goodnick Westenholz (1997: 248 note). It is mentioned in *Sargon King of Battle*, l. 4 see Goodnick Westenholz (1997: 103; 110) and in the *Great Rebellion against Naram-Sin* 7, cf. ibid. 222; 248.

25–8. *muḫḫum ša kursinātim* "marrow of shanks",[11] also from 1000 oxen and 6000 sheep, was served every day for 1000 cup-bearers (l. 25).

30–1. There was not enough ribsteak for the "rear party" among the 7000 "heroes".

33–5. The "last man" (or: the "rear party") among the 7000 "heroes" was/were then given meat of super-best quality otherwise reserved for "his throne", that is, a single ox and eight sheep reserved for pulling the leader's throne.[12]

36–7. Sargon's cook stupidly scorched some of the shanks (but note this time not said to be the "marrow" of shanks).[13]

38–40. The rank-and-file soldiers or "servants" (40: *ur-dí-a*) then had to be satisfied with an unspecified type of meat, probably the poorest sort, from 100 oxen and 200 sheep.[14]

On the one hand, this might be understood as an *aition* explaining the order of rank in Sargon's army, but since such an army hardly played any significant role in the Old Assyrian period, it makes little sense to see its intent as establishing, say, military etiquette for that period. Neither would there be any sense in searching for a cultic procedure in this 32-line-long section of the text, although such a question might be relevant to later parts of it (esp. l. 66). Could this, then, be understood as extolling Sargon's great organizing talent? This is actually implied, since this is part of what Sargon swears he has achieved (l. 19), but it is remarkable that Sargon's own role is somewhat ambiguous here, and far from as heroic as one could have expected. One can argue that a better understanding of the military terms and the different sorts of meat, etc., might lead to a much improved understanding, and this is undoubtedly true (cf. the contribution to this volume by J. Goodnick Westenholz). Nevertheless, it is indeed now already legitimate to ask whether this is instead a humorous episode in which some of the rear party were clever enough to get hold of the very best quality of meat, in spite of their unfavourable position.[15]

The rank-order at a banquet, who is going to come first to a banquet, and who will be seated first, are frequent themes, not only in literary contexts, but very much also in daily-life situations of many people.[16] Therefore, the intent may not have been directly to parodize Sargonic inscriptions, but simply to retell a theme from them in a humorous way (cf. further below).

Is it likely that such a story could have been told and written down in Old Assyrian Kaneš at all? If so, is the tablet to be understood as a "serious" inscription (or a copy from one), or is it to seen more as a quickly written improvisation, as suggested by Cavigneaux?[17]

[11] *muḫḫum*, is here understood as "marrow" of shanks, although "the choicest part" of shanks may also be considered, see below the comments on l. 26, and the appendix on *muḫḫum*.

[12] The reading "sheep" (UDU) is based on a minor emendation (of the otherwise unintelligible KU) in parallelism with the other slaughtered animals. If correct, this causes a minor anacoluthon, in that "of his throne" seems to imply that the ox was intended to be used to haul "his", that is, the captain's (l. 29), throne, whereas sheep could hardly have been used for such a purpose; cf. the comments below.

[13] The reading *gu₅-ur-na-am*, "mediocre meat", instead of *ku-ur-⟨si⟩-na-am*, "shanks", was suggested instead by Dercksen (2005: 109), but cf. the comments on l. 37 below.

[14] Perhaps the point is a bit more sophisticated, in that the "captain" tried to cheat by attempting to have some of the rear party among the 7000 "heroes" accept second-class meat ("ribsteaks" or "entrecôtes") instead of the first-class "marrow-of-shank" to which they were entitled, and then they got hold of the meat of super-royal quality to which they were not entitled, etc.

[15] Almost a folktale of the Benjamin type, cf. further below.

[16] For Sumerian literature see e.g. the discussion of *Lahar and Ašnan* by Alster and Vanstiphout (1987), and for Old Babylonian Mari, see Sasson (2004). It is also worth mentioning that the *Alexander Romance* (II 14–15.1) includes an episode in which Alexander, unrecognized and disguised as a messenger, dines at the seat of honour with Darius before the final battle. Any pupil at a boarding school, any soldier, any seaman, or any inmate in a prison can contribute similar stories, e.g. A. Solzhenitzyn in his concentration-camp novel *Gulag*. In general meals and banquet scenes are very prone to parodization. A good example is *Cena Cypriani* (4–5th cent. AD) which is a work from the period when Christianity had come to dominate the previous classical genres of satire. It was studied in a much acclaimed work by M. Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination* (1981). The best-known example from classical literature is Petronius' *Trimalchionis* (ref. N. W. Bruun).

[17] This plays a role with regard to the accuracy of the cuneiform text, cf. in particular the comments on ll. 34; 37; 62–3 below. The final lines written on the edge are so squeezed that it is difficult to decide to which lines some signs belong. Obviously the scribe had great difficulties in calculating how much space was needed. If it is true that a line has been misplaced (ll. 13 end–14 may make better sense before 17 end, as suggested by J. S. Cooper, cf. below), then it is likely that our tablet is based on a written model.

Apart from the style of writing, considerations regarding linguistic features,[18] the scribe's competence, education and training, other possible literary tablets,[19] as well as his other possible sources are also decisive for a better judgment.[20]

The literary creativity that comes to light here, among tradesmen whose main concern was business letters, should not come as a complete surprise.[21] Some early version of the Gilgameš epic must have been known,[22] since ll. 41ff., as explained by Cavigneaux, relate to the story as told later in the *Gilgameš Epic* tablet IX (cf. esp. 83–7; 140–65; 173–5), in which Gilgameš is said to have travelled through a tunnel of darkness and ended up finally seeing light in a vision like an enchanted garden of the Hesperides. The theme occurs already in the OB *Sargon King of Battle* legend as well as in omen literature.[23] Like our text *Sargon King of Battle*[24] seems to have been subdivided into sections similar to our "I swore by Adad, the lord of strength, and by Ištar, lady of battle", ll. 11–13; abbreviated in 18–19; 40–1.

In the context of royal praise poems extolling kings but discovered in private houses, we can also refer to a royal hymn or prayer to Marduk from OB Sippar (IM 85887), published by Al-Rawi (1992). This text appears to be composed for the sake of Hammurapi of the First Dynasty of Babylon or his son Ṣamsu-iluna, but was found in a private house in Sippar.[25] Charpin dates it to Samsu-iluna regnal year 8. For further discussion, see Charpin (2001).

Summary of the complete text

1–11 Historical introduction: Sargon as king and conqueror.
11–19 The gazelle-brick episode, showing Sargon's swiftness.
19–40 Sargon's dinner party (19–29: the big meal for everyone invited; 30–40: how the shortage problem was solved).
41–3 Sargon sitting in darkness (or: at the meal, cf. below) and leaving it after seven years in order to campaign.
44–7 Sargon "distributing" his "rod" to the "land", i.e. establishing his sovereignty there.
47–59 List of conquered peoples, mostly from east of Assyria towards the west, as far as Alašia (= Cyprus), where women were said to cover their heads.[26]

[18] Babylonian forms in the text were noted by Hecker (2001: 58) ("Altassyrisch mit einigen Babylonismen und offenbar Prosa"), but this does not prove that the text could not have originated in Assyria. It is likely that the scribe had been through studies of a normal scribal curriculum in Assur, similar to that of Nippur, including such Sumerian texts as *Šulgi Hymn B*, cf. Dercksen (2005: 112).

[19] Our tablet is written in prose with running lines that break irrespective of the syntactic structure. This is a format nearly unknown in OB Nippur, but it occurs in Old Sumerian texts, e.g. from Adab, cf. Alster (2005a: 195). The OA incantations (cf. n. 21 below) are written in similar ways, but details vary, cf. Michel 2004: 396 n. 7. Our text has vertical separating signs, here transliterated as :, after each word with its suffixes, yet with some exceptions (mostly not in connection with numerals, prepositions, conjunctions and ideograms). Remarkably these signs have been largely omitted in the final lines (59–66). If they had been used more consistently, they could have been useful in establishing the best reading in, say, ll. 34 and 62–3. Running lines that frequently break the syntactic structure is a "non-poetic" format well known in the West, such as tablets inscribed with Gilgameš tales from Megiddo, Emar and Boğazkale, cf. George (2003: 340). The same lack of coordination between lines and sentence units also occurs on some early OB tablets from Tell Ḥarmal, thus no. 7, *Sargon in Foreign Lands*, in Goodnick Westenholz (1997: 78–93) (ref. J.G.W).

[20] It would be most helpful if e.g. a source for the first signs in l. 29 could be identified. If the reading proposed below is justified, the scribe must have been very well educated.

[21] A. Finet (1974: 35–47, esp. 37 and 40), discusses whether an episode of the Gilgamesh Epic is echoed in the royal correspondance of Mari. The phrase in question, *pišātīya u errētīya* "things that insult and revile me" (VI 86; cf. VI 85), is in fact not characteristic enough to warrant such a conclusion. The penetrating study by J.-M. Durand (2006) points rather to Amorite or bedouin oral proverbs as sources of sententious phrases quoted in the royal correspondance of Mari. The only nearly comparable OA texts are seven incantations, three of which are published by Michel (1997a; 2004), and others by von Soden (1956): BIN 4 126; Veenhof (1996): Kt a/k 611; and Hecker (1996): Kt a/k 320; one will be published by M. Trolle Larsen (cf. Michel 2004: 395 nn. 2–4).

[22] An unpublished Old Assyrian text (kt k/49), contains the personal name *Gi$_5$-il$_5$-ga-mì-iš*, as first recognized by K. Hecker and reported by George (2003: 78, n. 53), with more details.

[23] See Cavigneaux (2005: 599). The Sargonic legend concerning the journey through darkness appears in two OB legends, No. 6 *Sargon the Conquering Hero*, and No. 7 *Sargon in Foreign Lands* in Goodnick Westenholz (1997: 59–77; 78–93), cf. the comments on l. 42 below.

[24] Very fragmentary, though, as preserved in Goodnick Westenholz (1997: 114, l. 18).

[25] Al-Rawi comments in his edition that the manuscript was found in a broken jar together with documents that bear the date formulae of Samsu-iluma year 7 or year 8, see Al-Rawi (1992: 79, n. 1).

[26] Veiling is otherwise known in Middle Assyria, Emar and the Bible, see van der Toorn (1995); also Akk. *pasāmum* v., *pussunu* adj., *pusummu* s.; an example occurs in an OA letter, AKT 3, 80:22: *pusunnam ina qaddad ṣuḫartim ašakkanma*, "when PN arrives I will place the veil upon the

59–60 "Besides": Kaneš released of ... (rest uncertain).
61–2 Further conquered peoples, ending with the Ḫaḫḫa'ans.
63 (All resistance was fruitless, because anyway) now that Adad is king, all these peoples have to contribute to making Sargon's funeral offering abundant!

The sequence of foreign peoples starts almost as a serious account of Sargon's campaigns, resulting in the setting up of a statue of Sargon, which is nearly realistic.[27] It leads through Ḫumanum,[28] reaches even as far as Cyprus,[29] and includes a description of some conquered peoples. These are mostly said to be dressed or shaven like barbarians.[30] Prisoners were normally shown as naked on reliefs depicting victory scenes. The interest in headdresses and hair-style in this case may therefore be motivated by these being the only easily recognizable features by means of which naked people can be distinguished (cf. Cavigneaux 2005: 600).

In our case, however, the interest in people's headdresses (and jewellery! l. 62) may also well have been motivated by natural curiosity caused by involvement in textile trade, or, alternatively, a grotesque pleasure in depicting (commercial) rivals as humiliated, and in fact the text seems tacitly to move into that direction.[31] The precise understanding depends very much on how two lines (60 and 62) are understood. The treatment of the people of Kaneš of course applies to the "local" population, and not to the Assyrian colony, who would undoubtedly have enjoyed such stories. Ḫaḫḫum,[32] which follows in l. 62, was a key station on the trade route leading to Kaneš, so its humiliation, if so understood, might be seen in the same vein. The positive alternative translation, referring to the thriving of textile trade, would also make good sense.

A close reading of ll. 50–9, however, gives a more precise impression of the type of humiliation to which the enemies are exposed: these aim specifically at depriving the men of their male characteristics (esp. 57),[33] making them appear "effeminate", and dressed as women (esp. 54), a very severe humiliation.

The concluding lines (64–6) resume the two main themes of the composition, 1) Sargon as conqueror, and 2) Sargon's meal. They summarize the whole composition from the point of view of the funeral cult of Sargon, implying, apparently humorously, that all resistance was fruitless, because in the end Adad is king, and all the conquered peoples will contribute to making the dead king's food provisions abundant, in terms of his funeral cult.

lass" (refs. J.G.W). Cf. *pasāmu* AHw 838, verhüllen (Demon), a/jB; *paṣānu* AHw 840, verhüllen, a/nA.

[27] In view of the Bassetki statue with an inscription of Naramsin, found in Northern Iraq (although perhaps not originally intended to be placed there), and, not least, the Pir Hüseyin relief of Naramsin at Diyarbakir, cf. J. Goodnick Westenholz (1998: 12, with n. 30), Istanbul Altor. Mus. 1027 = V. Scheil RT 15 (1893) 62 ff. = BE 1, 120, etc. Goodnick Westenholz, ibid. esp. pp. 10–11 reviews the textual evidence for Naramsin's northern campaigns, of which one year date seems to concern his penetration into Anatolia (the sources of the Euphrates and the Tigris) (met with some skepticism by Van De Mieroop 2000). She lists some archaeological evidence ibid. 13–14 (N.B. written 10 years earlier than published!). Cf. also the exotic jar of an Anatolian type depicted on an Akkadian victory stele conveniently reproduced in N. Postgate (1992: 255, fig. 13:6) from *Boston Museum Bulletin* 68 (1970) 230, reconstructed by J. F. X. McKeon, drawn by S. Chapman.

[28] Ḫumānum is no longer thought to be Amanus or Lebanon, cf. Dercksen (2005: 113–14), who points out that the writing *Ḫu-* instead of *Ḫa-* militates against identifying it with the Amanus, which is written *A-ma-nam* and *A-ma-nim* in Sargonic inscriptions (see *FAOS* 8, 117). The line shows that the theme of the split mountain was a literary topic already then, cf. George (2003: 467–8). If somewhere on the way to Anatolia, the "route" seems not quite realistic, in that Tukris and Hutura seem to refer to locations further east, and hardly on the way to Cyprus. Cf. also note to l. 48 below with n. 51.

[29] This is not realistic, however. Although there are now some signs of connections between the Akkadian dynasty and Anatolia, cf. n. 27 above, no one would seriously claim that Sargon went as far as Alašia (= Cyprus), which is mentioned for the first time here in cuneiform texts.

[30] This necessitates an additional comment on a theory proposed by Alster (2005b), who suggests that the very fragmentary lower register on the reverse of the *Stele of the Vultures* depicts a battle scene between a ruler of Lagaš and a leader of Umma. Later J. Cooper (private communication) cast doubt on that interpretation: the lower register is more likely to depict warriors already taken captive, since it seems to show naked people lined up in the same way as on other early reliefs.

[31] Foster (2005: 71) "ethnic jokes no longer understandable" seems to share a similar opinion.

[32] Ḫaḫḫum: See Van De Mieroop (2000: 153); Foster (2005: 74, n. 6) with refs. to previous literature, and G. Barjamovic's forthcoming dissertation for a complete treatment of the subject. It was the main entrepôt into Anatolia and home of an Assyrian colony, and in later tradition was said to have been conquered by Sargon.

[33] This was suggested by G. Barjamovic.

Conclusion: Not a parody but a humorous overstatement

In the opinion of the present authors, Hecker first of all in his admirably brief pioneering study provides a good textual basis to start with, whereas Cavigneaux hits the tone of the text best. Yet some fundamental issues invite more discussion.

Is it convincing that it was a stele erected in a temple in Assur that inspired it? Very different conclusions can be suggested by taking into account an approach advocated by A. Westenholz (1999: 20–4), albeit more generally with regard to OAkk literature and its possible OB relations, but nonetheless certainly also relevant to this particular text.

First of all, there are good reasons to believe that a number of tales circulated in oral form, including tales about the great Sargonic kings, not only as written documents.[34] These tales may have been familiar to many people, who could have told them and recognized them without being dependent on any particular written text. Central among these tales was what Westenholz designates an oral "Akkade saga" (p. 22).[35] It is much more likely that the picture painted of the Sargonic king(s) in our text reflects such oral tales, than that they were directly inspired by a stele erected in a temple.

With this go questions concerning the character of some rare examples of literary exercise tablets written as modest scribal exercises, versus some first-quality master examples, to which royal stelae erected in the temples undoubtedly belonged.[36] In Westenholz's words (p. 22) "Most of the Old Babylonian 'legends', including those about the Great Rebellion, are humble school exercises by beginners or slightly advanced students, no doubt reproducing popular tales familiar to teacher and student alike. The handwriting and spelling in the Old Babylonian tablets range from pathetic to passable, and there is little textual stability". This also applies to the few known OB examples of tablets about Gilgameš, the purpose of which "was presumably to train the students to set down a known text from memory in writing."[37] The fact that such tales spread to the Hittite-speaking areas, etc., does not support Liverani's theories.[38]

[34] A similar opinion was expressed by Alster (1995: 2323) "A ... decisive factor was undoubtedly the presence of a rich tradition of folklore and mythology, most of which is now lost to us ... the art of storytelling existed and just had to be modified to suit the new purposes. This explains why the poems themselves combine features of mythology and folktale with realistic scenes belonging to the royal court". Cf. already Oppenheim (1977: 22) and Cooper (1992: 109). Also George (2003: esp. 17–22) considers oral story telling a realistic source of Gilgameš tales in Mesopotamian history. Also seminal is the study by Goodnick Westenholz (1992) who observes, i.a., that some variants in the transmission of the *Great Rebellion* cannot be explained by means of a traditional stemma alone, but must reflect the existence of oral tales as well. Cf. n. 44 below.

[35] Alternatively *Gesta Akkadorum*, although never compiled into a single composition. These also included a number "historical" omens (cf. Westenholz 1999: n. 19), as well as some "chronicles" (cf. ibid. n. 20). The rarely attested *Sumerian Sargon Legend* is the most conspicuous example, cf. Cooper and Heimpel (1983), Alster (1987), Afanas'eva (1987) and Attinger (1994). By contrast the *Curse of Agade* became one of the most frequently copied of all Sumerian literary compositions.

[36] Like rare library books reserved for a limited group of connoisseurs versus posters on newspaper stands, or students' homework.

[37] We can therefore dismiss all attempts to see such modest tablets as indicative of an "intertextual" literary "discourse" or "propagandistic" creations in the sense that has become fashionable in recent years, cf. Westenholz's criticism (1999: 20); also Potts (2001, esp. 396–7; 405). On the other hand, the modestly written school tablets can be seen in the light of what George (2003, esp. 35) describes as a two-stage scribal education. These obviously belonged to the elementary level, which took advantage of the familiarity of a number of tales among the students (implying that oral stories circulated). Cf. further George (loc. cit.) "some [OB] learner scribes were demonstrating very capably that they could set down on clay episodes from Babylonian narrative poetry, whether by extemporizing, by composing from memory or by copying from a master tablet". Potts (2001: 392) acknowledges that "Some [sc. of the Sargonic corpus] may be early attempts to write down oral legends or to turn royal inscriptions into epic tales for wider dissemination ...".

Proverbs represent another aspect of oral "literature" that has been largely overlooked. A recent trend is to see the Sumerian proverb collections as utilitarian products of the curriculum of the schools, in which they were allegedly used for introducing grammar and for lexical training. Alster and Oshima (2006: esp. 35–45) object to this, arguing that neither the study of grammar nor lexicography were main objectives of the proverb collections, especially since a number of words do not recur in both text groups. Alster (2007: esp. 5–7) goes a step further, showing that sometimes the proverb collections were even utterly inappropriate for instructing grammar, since a number of proverbs tend to occur in forms that are so truncated that they simply do not make sense unless accompanied with a fuller wording, which must have been supplied orally, or considered familiar in advance.

[38] Westenholz (1999: 22): "According to Liverani, [the] story about Sargon's rescue of his merchants at Purushkhanda was invented as an argument in a debate in the city-council at Assur under Shamsi-adad — the real 'Sargon' — for the resumption of the earlier Old Assyrian trade on Anatolia which had been interrupted. Liverani does not explain how such a background paper for an executive meeting in Assur could become literary tradition among Babylonians and Hittites ... nor how a piece of brand-new fiction entered into the divinatory lore". Liverani, (2001–2: 180) objects to this criticism, but there is in fact a serious problem here. A crucial point made by

A common characteristic of such texts is the telescoping of history into exemplary types. Another common feature is that anachronism abounds. Typically Sargon and Naramsin remained in memory for more than a generation,[39] whereas Šarkališarri was soon forgotten, although he was actually responsible for some of the deeds ascribed to Naramsin.[40] As pointed out by Westenholz (1999: 23 with n. 28), many parallels from world literature can be adduced for comparison.[41] Some general rules characterizing such tales were actually formulated long ago.[42]

A characteristic example of anachronism is the invention of writing in *Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta*, which does not aim at telling something about historical reality, but is simply there to demonstrate Enmerkar's superior cunning.[43] The theme is alluded to in the *Sumerian Sargon Legend*, in which the invention of the envelope similarly has nothing to do with historical reality, but is simply there as an enjoyable variation on the same theme, showing Sargon's cleverness in avoiding being killed.[44] Our text has another example of anachronism: Here Sargon swears by

Potts (2001: esp. 397), is that what we have preserved is statistically very unlikely to represent more than a fraction of the total corpus available in antiquity. Our Old Assyrian Sargon Legend beautifully proves the point, since this unique text is enough to change totally the picture of a tradition that nobody would have thought existed.

[39] Maništušu was also remembered up to the Neo-Babylonian period, see Goodnick Westenholz (1997: 3 n. 8). Rimuš also received offerings later, but neither of them became part of the legendary tradition.

[40] Similar opinions were expressed by Alster (1995: 2322): "One has to accept the fundamental fictional character of literary art ... it serves little purpose to discuss whether the stories contain anachronistic details, because, as is generally the case with legends and folktales, they telescope everything into exemplary behaviour where the realistic is imagined, and they do not aim at correctness in any historical sense". Typical examples are the wall around Uruk traditionally ascribed to Gilgameš; Enmerkar/Lugalbanda and the Martu-wall, etc.

[41] Including European medieval literature. A. Westenholz (private communication), refers to the Norwegian *Þiðrek's Saga* (late 13th cent. AD, cf. Lukman 1941), in which the author initially states that he knows his story from German merchants who traded in Norway. The story itself concerns the Ostrogothic king Theuderic of Italy, who died in AD 526. The Ostrogothic rule was terminated by Justinian (530–60), so it is remarkable that its king was remembered as Thidrek/Dietrich in the Germanic world during more than 700 years of oral tradition. He is even mentioned in a Swedish runic inscription from the 9th century (Rökstenen). This places our text in quite a new perspective. Merchants did not always talk about money!

For a recent discussion of *Þiðrek's Saga* with references to earlier literature see Susanne Kramarz-Bein (2002, ref. courtesy Maria Alster). In Kramarz-Bein's understanding the saga is thought to have been composed during king Hákon IV Hákonarson's reign (1217–63). It is known from 22 manuscripts, the oldest of which is a palimpsest dating from the end of the 13th century AD. The residential city of this king was Bergen, where a colony of Hanseatic German merchants also resided. Apparently he sought to establish a literary court tradition with links to central European court literature, Anglo-Saxon legends about king Arthur, as well as a native Old Nordic saga-tradition. *Þiedrek's Saga* has otherwise mostly been considered a conglomerate of Germanic legendary tales, including both translated texts and orally transmitted tales, a "Kompilationswerk", or even a "Heldensagen-Sammelsurium" (Kramarz-Bein 2002: 1). From a comparative perspective it is interesting that the German Hanseatic merchants held a position in Bergen similar to that of the Old Assyrian merchants at Kaneš.

[42] Alster (1995: 2323 f.) in the same vein refers to the "epic laws" formulated by Axel Olrik in the early twentieth century (his main work was published in Danish in 1921, but his ideas were known in Germany from 1909 onwards and their influence is visible in Gunkel's Genesis commentary). M. Vogelzang (1988: 177–82) deserves credit for having seen the relevance of Olrik's theories to Akkadian literature. The sixth of Olrik's laws, "The weakest or worst in a group turns out to be the best. The youngest brother or sister is normally the victor" clearly applies to the final success of the latecomers in the meal episode of our text.

[43] Cf. Vanstiphout (1989) for a different opinion regarding Enmerkar's alleged invention of writing.

[44] Cf. Alster (1995: 2320–1). This implies that what may be termed "intertextuality" does not have to be meant in the way justly criticised by Westenholz (1999: 20 ff.), but rather, it is a useful term that implies that texts can play on the recognizability of common themes, like musicians playing a *tema con variazioni*. What is said here in no way implies that the bulk of Sumerian literary compositions is folkloristic, only that many folkloristic elements are included. There is a clear distinction between such elaborate standardized compositions as the *Curse of Agade* and epics about Enmerkar and Lugalbanda, which are known from many beautifully written copies, versus a rare composition such as the *Sumerian Sargon Legend*. Similarly, there is a clear distinction between the rare OB school tablets inscribed with short tales about Gilgameš and the later standardized Gilgameš epic, or even the OB P and Y tablets. A symposium held in Groningen 1990 resulted in a volume (Vogelzang and Vanstiphout 1992) that includes many arguments for abandoning the sharp distinction between "written" and "oral" "literature", thus Alster pp. 23–69; Cooper pp. 103–22. The discussion by Goodnick Westenholz (ibid. 123–54, note esp. pp. 136 and 141) is seminal, for she demonstrates that the textual history of the *Great Rebellion against Naram-Sin* and its later reflection in the *Cuthean Legend* cannot be explained by means of a written tradition alone, but presupposes an oral tradition. Some "written" literatures may draw heavily upon "oral" sources, and similar aesthetics may widely apply to both, therefore in the title of Vogelzang (1992) "aural" puns on "oral". An observation by B. Schipper (2005) opens new perspectives, also relevant to Mesopotamian literature. Some Egyptian wisdom texts became widely known through a characteristic way of scribal training: initial sentences, closing sentences and important keywords were explicitly written down and learnt by heart, and following generations were left to "co-author" their own versions in a way that is neither written or oral alone, but combines features of both. A wealth of information on the relations between written and orally transmitted literature can be gained from the journal *Oral Tradition* of the University of Missouri, founded in 1986, accessible since September 2006 on the website http://journal.oraltradition.org.

Ištar and Adad, but in the Old Akkadian Sargonic inscriptions Rimuš swore by Šamaš and Ilaba (cf. Dercksen 2005: 117), whereas Naramsin swore by Enlil and Šamaš and by Inanna-Annunitum and Enlil. To assess the place of such tales or "legends" in Mesopotamian culture, it suffices neither to see them solely as "historical documents" nor as "literary texts", but one must approach them "as multidimensional entities that have a historical dimension as well as a literary dimension ... at the same time" (Potts 2001: 405).

It is possible to suggest how such a text may have developed as an improvisation based on a stable pattern easy to remember. The beginning of the text may clearly be a paraphrase on royal Sargonic inscriptions. The end was also easy to recall as a conclusion stating that Sargon's supreme power was to be memorized in the funeral cult of later generations. What comes between is a sequence of episodes of varying length, all starting with a "refrain" easy to remember, "I swear by Adad and Ištar, etc." (ll. 15 f.; cf. 18 f.; 40 f.). These episodes may have been prone to improvisation, which explains their flexible length. The logical coherence between these should not necessarily be stressed too much. Thus, in ll. 19 f., the meal episode does not directly issue from the gazelle-episode; in ll. 41 f., the episode in which Sargon makes his power manifest among the peoples is perhaps related to the preceding meal episode, but perhaps not. Any narrator might have been able to add or abbreviate according his taste or the fund of tales known to him, as well as the constraints of outer circumstances, such as the length of his tablet, or the patience of his audience.

Conclusion: The big meal in our text is meant as a humorous overstatement of the king's generosity, with folkloristic features, but it is not a parody. It is comparable to Assur-nasirpal's big feast celebrating the construction of his new capital, Kalhu. The *Old Assyrian Sargon Legend* can be seen as originating in the same fund of orally transmitted tales about Sargon as also comes to light in the *Sumerian Sargon Legend*, and the Akkadian *Birth Legend of Sargon*. We would not consider it unlikely that a similar text, if not a direct duplicate, will sooner or later turn up, who knows, maybe if Ḫaḫḫum is ever excavated?

Accepting the text as a legend in the sense described by J. Goodnick Westenholz,[45] we may therefore conclude that it is indeed possible to bring the suggestions made in particular by Hecker (a laudatory royal inscription), Dercksen (a text extolling Sargon in funeral celebrations), Cavigneaux (an improvisation recalling Sargonic royal inscriptions), and W. R. Mayer (features of fairy tales) together in a singular formula by considering the *Old Assyrian Sargon Legend* as an early example of the same type of heroic literature as comes to light in the later *Alexander Romance*.[46] This likewise combines historical deeds with features of fairy tales, including written records as well as orally transmitted tales. The characteristic pseudo-autobiographical forms of the *narû*-literature seems, however, to be specific to Mesopotamian sources. It is similar to such features as the inclusion of pseudo-letters from Alexander to his mother, as well as to Aristotle, his alleged teacher, in the *Alexander Romance*, which were aimed at conveying the impression of genuine history.

[45] Goodnick Westenholz (1997: 22) quotes a well-known definition by Bascom: "Prose narratives which, like myths, are regarded as true by the narrator and his audience, but set in a period considerably less remote, when the world was much as it is today. They tell of migrations, wars and victories, deeds of past heroes, chiefs and kings, and succession in ruling dynasties", which is very much relevant to our text.

[46] An English translation of the *Alexander Romance* is easily available as a Penguin Classic: *The Greek Alexander Romance*, transl. R. Stoneman (1991). As known today it presumably goes back to a Greek text compiled in Alexandria in Egypt towards the end of the third century AD. What is said here is in no way meant to imply that the *Alexander Romance* or parts of it are in any way directly derived from Mesopotamian "forerunners". Such a perspective has sometimes been suggested, but, as shown by George (2003: 66–7 with nn. 186–7), those specific suggestions which have been made are unconvincing, either because of erroneous etymologies, or because orally transmitted tales are much more likely to explain a number of similarities. It is the literary type as such that is of interest in our perspective. The *Alexander Romance* basically tells the legendary story of Alexander's birth, his ascent to power, his victory in particular over Darius, and his subsequent conquest of the world. His alleged descent from an Egyptian god (Nectanebo/Ammon) makes him half divine, and oracles, omens and dreams foretelling his later success play a great role in the story, somewhat like Mesopotamian tales about Sargon. The frame of the whole story at least partly reflects historical realities intermingled with more or less fanciful tales. These spread all over Asia, and a number of versions exist in no less than 35 languages. The authoritative Greek text edition is by Helmut van Thiel (1983). This information is provided from Harsberg (1987: esp. 7–17 and 114).

Transliteration and translation of Kt. j/k 97

1 LUGAL : LUGAL-*ki-in* : LUGAL
2 *a-ke-dé-e* : *ri-be-tim* : LUGAL
3 *da-num* : *ša iš-tí i-le-e*
4 *e-ta-wu-ni* : ^{d}*adad da-nu-tám*
5 *i-dí-šu-ma* : *iš-tù ṣi-it*
6 *ša-am-ší-im* : *a-dí e-ra-áb*
7 *ša-am-ší-im* : *ma-tám* : *aṣ-ba-at-ma*
8 *i-na* u_4*-mi-im* : *iš-té-en*$_6$
9 *a-na* 70 *a-lá-ni kà-kà-am* : *a-dí-in*
10 *ru-ba-e-šu-nu ú-ṣa-bi*$_4$*-it* : *ù a-li-šu-nu*
11 *ú-ḫa-li-iq* : ^{d}*adad be-el* : *e-mu-qí-im*
12 *ù iš*$_8$*-tár* : *be-lá-at* : *ta-ḫa-zi-im*
13 *at-ma* : *ṣa-bi*$_4$*-tám* : *a-mu-ur-ma* : *li-bi*$_4$*-tám*
14 *a-na na-ri-im* : *a-dí-ma* : *i-na*
15 *lá-sà-mì-a* : *mu-sà-ri* : *i-bi*$_4$*-tí-iq-ma*
16 ṣa(/sà/ZA)*-ar-a-am* : *áš-ta-kà-an-ma* : *al-sú-ma*
17 *ṣa-bi*$_4$*-tám* : *aṣ-ba-at* : *li-bi*$_4$*-tám*
18 *i-ma-e* : *ú-šé-li* : ^{d}*adad ù iš*$_8$*-tár*
19 *a*[*t-m*]*a* : 1 *li-im* gud.ḫi.a : 6 *li-me-e*
20 udu.ḫi.a : *ú-mì-ša-ma* : *lu ú-ṭa-ba-aḫ*
21 7 : *li-me-e* : *qá-*[*r*]*a-du-a* : *ša i-ra-tim*
22 *ú-mì-ša-ma ma-aḫ-ri-a e-ku-lu-ni*
23 3 : *li-me-e* : *lá-sí-mu-ú-a*
24 *ša* : *ar-kà-tim* : *e-ku-lu-ni*
25 1 *li-im* : *ša-qí-ú-a*
26 u_4*-mì-ša-ma* : *mu-ḫa-am*
27 *ša* KUR-*ur-sí-na-tim* : *a-dí-i*
28 *ša-ba-im* : *e-ku-lu-ni*
29 NISAG.DU-*i iq-re-e-ma*
30 7 *li-me-e* : *qá-ra-du-a*
31 *i-ra-tim* : *e-ku-lu* : *a-na*
32 *wa-ar-ki-im* : *i-ir-tum*
33 *lá ik-šu-ud-ma* : *a-lá-áp-šu*
34 udu(! copied: KU) *ša-ma-ni-a-am ša ku-sí-i-šu*
35 *iṭ-bu-ùḫ-ma* : *a-na wa-ar-ki-im*
36 *i-ir-tám* : *i-dí-in* : *nu-ḫi-tí-mì*
37 *ku-ur-*⟨*sí-*⟩*na-am* : *ú-ri-ir-ma*
38 *a-na ar-ni-šu* : 1 *me-et* gud.ḫi.a
39 2 *me-et* udu.ḫi.a : *iṭ-bu-ùḫ-ma*
40 *ur-dí-a* : *ú-ša-ki-il*$_5$: ^{d}*adad*
41 *ù iš*$_8$*-tár* : *at-ma* : mu 7 ŠÈ iti-kam
42 *ù ša-pá-tám* : *i-na i-ki-il*$_5$*-tim*
43 *qá-du* : *um-mì-ni-a* : *lu ú-ší-ib*
44 *i-na wa-ṣa-i-a* : *ša* ^{na_4}gug
45 *ù* ^{na_4}za-gìn : *qá-nu-a-am*
46 *lu ar-ku-ús-ma* : *a-na ma-tim*
47 *lu ú-za-iz* : *ša-du-a-am* : *ḫu-ma-nam*
48 *a-ší-ni-šu* : *am-ḫa-sú-ma* : *ki-ma*
49 *sí-ki-tim* : *i-ba-ri-šu-nu ṣa-al-mì*
50 *ú-ša-zi-iz* : *ru-ba-am*
51 *ša tù-uk-ri-iš* : *maš-kam ú-lá-bi*$_4$*-iš*
52 *ḫu-tù-ra* : *bi*$_4$*-bi*$_4$*-na-tim qá-qá-da-tí-šu-nu*
53 *aš-ku-un* : *a-lá-ší-am* : *ki-ma*

54 *sí-ni-iš-tim : qá-qá-da-tí-šu-nu*
55 *ak-tù-um : ša a-mu-re-e*
56 *ki-ma : a-pì-šu-nu : ša-ma-ṭim*
57 *i-ša-ar-šu-nu : aq-tí-i : ša ki-lá-re-e*
58 *i-mar-ší-im : qá-qá-da-tí-šu-nu*
59 *ar-ku-ús ša-ni-um kà-ni-ší-⟨e⟩*
60 ZU-DU-*ḫi-šu-nu ú-šé-er*
61 *ša ḫa-tim qá-ba-al-tí : qá-qá-da-tí-šu-nu : ú-ša-ag-li-ib : lu-ùḫ-me-e*
62 *tù-dí-tám : ú-dí-id : qú-tí-tám : lu-lu-am : ù ḫa-ḫa-am ṣu-ba-tí-šu-nu ú-ša-ri*
(or read *ú-ša-ri-im* if IM belongs here?)
63 13(?) *zi-qí ša-ma-e : i-qá-tí-a : al-pu-ut : mì-na-am i-ṭup-pì-im*
(or read *i-ṭup-pè* if IM belongs to l. 62?)
64 *lu-ša-am-i-id : a-nu-um : lá i-di-a-ni : ki-ma* LUGAL *a-na-ku-ni*
65 *ma-tám e-li-tám ù ša-áp-li-tám aṣ-bu-tù-ni* ^{d}*adad* LUGAL
66 *ša-tù-uk-ki li-ša-ar-bi*$_4$*-ú*

1–4 King Sargon, king of the metropolis Akkade, the mighty king who converses with the gods,
4–7 Adad gave him strength, and so: from sunrise to sunset
I took possession of the land, and
8–9 in a single day I delivered battle to 70 cities.
10–11 I captured their princes and destroyed their cities.
11–13 I swore by Adad, the lord of strength, and Ištar, lady of battle:
13–14 I saw a gazelle and I threw a mud brick into the river,
15 but while I was running my belt broke,
16–17 so I put on a snake.
I ran, and so I (both) caught the gazelle
18–19 and picked up the mud brick from the water!
19 I swore by Adad and Ištar: 1000 oxen and 6000 sheep
20 I used to slaughter every day.
21–2 7000 were my "heroes", who used to eat ribsteaks every day before me
23–4 — (and) my 3000 runners who used to eat sirloin(-steaks),
25–8 — (and) my 1000 cup-bearers who used to eat
26–2 marrow-of-shanks every day
28 to the point of complete satisfaction
29 — my "captain" invited (all these).
30–1 (Thus) my 7000 "heroes" ate ribsteaks,
31–3 but there was not enough ribsteak(-meat) for the "last man",
33–5 so he slaughtered his
34 ox and eight sheep(!) belonging to his throne
35–6 and gave the ribsteak(-meat) to the last man.
36–7 But my cook scorched the shanks,
38 so for his punishment he (had to) slaughter 100 oxen and 200 sheep, and
40 he had to feed my "rank-and-file soldiers" (lit. slaves/servants) with those!
41 I swore by Adad and Ištar: I sat in darkness (or: at the meal) for seven years, a month,
42–3 and fifteen days with my troops!
44–6 When I came out, I bound a rod of carnelian and lapis lazuli,
46–7 and distributed it to the land.
47–8 I smote the Ḫumanum mountain into two parts
49–50 and I set up my statue like a peg between them.
50–1 I made the prince of Tukriš wear an animal hide.
52–3 I put slave-marks on the heads of (the people of) Ḫutura.
53–5 I covered the heads (of the people of) Alašia (Cyprus)
54 like women.
55–7 As to the Amorites, instead of tearing off their nose, I cut off their penis.

58 9 As to (the people of) Kilari, I bound their heads in rein(s).
59 60 *In addition*: I released (the people of) Kaneš *of* their ...
61 As to (the people of) Ḫatti, I had their heads shaven in the middle.
61 2 I *pinched* the Luḫme'ans with a Gutian brooch.
62 I made the garments of the Lulu'ans and the Ḫaḫḫa'ans sumptuous.
63 I touched 13(?) *mountain tops* of the sky with my hand.
63 4 Why should I expand on this in a tablet?
64 Anum has not let me down since I am the king
65 — (and since) I conquered the land from north to south! —
65 6 let them, oh Adad king, make the regular offering for me abundant!

Comments

2. The reading of *a-ke-dé-e ri-be-tim* follows CAD R 317f. (*ribītu* A "street, main street, thoroughfare"); see also Mayer 2003: 238–9. *ri-be-tim* is here tentatively translated "metropolis". This literary epithet is a short expression for "city of great streets and squares" (so Foster 2005: 72). It is traditionally used of Uruk or Akkad. It corresponds to Sum. sila-daṇal-la or tílla, a square or the intersection of streets.

4. *e-ta-wu-ni*, implies that Sargon was privileged enough to converse directly with the gods or, less likely, that he was dead, cf. Cavigneaux (2005: 598). Later Cavigneaux (private communication) provided a reference to Wilcke (1997: 24 viii 27): [*mu-ta*[1]-*w*]*i Ištar u annunītim*, with comments p. 29f., said about Naramsin. Wilcke's restoration is based on the Geneva version l. 4 of the *Great Rebellion* against Naramsin (read [*mu-ša-p*]*i* in Goodnick Westenholz 1997: 240). *Šulgi B* 42: šul-gi-me-en dalla è-bi-a inim mu-un-da-bal-e-en, "I Šulgi, converse with him (= Utu) wherever it (the sun) rises in glory", may have been known from the school curriculum, cf. Dercksen (2005: 114). In the *Alexander Romance* (I 1.3) "to converse with the gods" implies concretely the understanding of magic or the ability to interpret oracles, which would make good sense here.

5. The transition from the 3rd to the 1st person "pourrait relever de la parodie de l'inscription royale, où elle est fréquente" (Cavigneaux 2005: 596). Hecker (2001: 58), however, understands this as a possible sign of contamination of two sources. An explanation seems, however, to be that the initial lines in the third person function as a kind of historical introduction to the king's boasting monologue, clearly set off by *-ma*, "and so".

13 18. Cavigneaux (2005: 599) thinks of "un exploit sportif (une sorte de triathlon avec course, lancer de brique et plongée)". A number of examples of runners or running as a kind of athletic performance in the ancient Near East are discussed by Demsky (2005: esp. p. 88, n. 12) with a list of previous literature, to which can be added Rolliger (1994) (mainly dealing with wrestling and boxing, however). Šulgi, according to *Šulgi Hymn A*, could run a round trip of ca. 300 kms in one day. Biblical references to runners are: David's Heroes 1 Chr 12:8; 2 Sam 15:1; Jer 51:31–2; Jer 12:5 and Talmudic refs. discussed by Demsky. In 2 Sam 2:18 Asael is said to be "as fleet as a gazelle", which shows that the gazelle was proverbial because of its swiftness, as in SP 18.8 (quoted below).

Šulgi Hymn B 108 also connects the king's swiftness with a gazelle: šul-gi-me-en dùb šu bar-ra-gin$_7$ MAŠ àm-mi-íb-dab$_5$-bé-en "I Šulgi, I can catch a gazelle when running (lit. like spreading knees)". A Sumerian proverb SP 18.8 with parallels, modified reading (see Alster and Oshima 2006: 57 under Geneva Proverbs i 19 ii 1), reads: lú dùb-tuku MAŠ in-dab lú á-tuku ba-da-am(sic!)-kar lú eme-tuku é-gal-ʳla ba[1]-[ku$_4$], "A swift runner caught a gazelle; a strong man carried it away, but one who could use (eloquent) speech brought it into the palace", which also seems to allude to such sportive events (note that MAŠ is an old writing for maš-dà = *ṣabītu*, "gazelle"). The intent is slightly different, however, in that someone other than he who did the job was credited with it. Cf. further below under ll. 16–18, 2) and OECT 11, 2: 19–22 (incantation for soothing a baby, see Farber (1989: 34ff.).

15. *mu-sà-ri* is from *musarrum*, which is the OA form of *miserru* "belt, girdle" (CAD M 110); AHw 658 *musarru* "Gürtel". *i-na lá-sà-mì-a*, "while I was running" suggests that it was simply Sargon's great physical strength as a runner that caused the belt to break.

i-bi$_4$-ti-iq = N *ibbitiq*. The *-ma* following it clearly means "so/thus/therefore".

16 18. The interpretation of the whole section depends on how to understand 16: ZA-*ar-a-am*. The following suggestions can be made:

1) Hecker (2001: 58, n. 16a) suggests that ZA-*ar-a-am* is identical to *sari(j)am* "Lederpanzer" (cf. AHw 1059b; CAD S 313 *siriam*, "leather coat, often reinforced with metal pieces"). This was recognized by AHw as a Hurrian word, *sariyam*, cf. also CDA, p. 318 *sari(y)am*. It occurs in Ebla, see Bonechi and Conti (1992). They also refer to Hebrew *š/siryôn*, Syriac *šeryonô*, etc.

Hecker translates 13–18 "Eine Gazelle sah ich und warf einen Ziegel in den Fluß. Bei meinem Laufen ging mein Gürtel verloren. Daher legte ich einen *Lederpanzer* an. Dann konnte ich laufen und die Gazelle fangen. Den Ziegel nahm ich aus dem Wasser heraus". If justified, the leather coat is motivated as a garment that

proves Sargon's ability to run, because in spite of its heavier weight he was able to run fast enough to catch the gazelle. Our *aštakan-ma* is *šakānum* Gt prt.[47]

2) ZA-*ar-a-am* derives from *ṣar'um*, cf. CAD Ṣ 115 *ṣar'u* "snake", which is the OA form of *ṣērum* "snake" (AHw *ṣerru(m)*). This is Cavigneaux's solution, who translates "ma ceinture fendit, ET je mis un serpent (à sa place), ET me remit à courir" (ET = *-ma*), etc.; he was thus first to recognize the word in our text, and is followed here. The word was first recognized by Michel in the incantation she published (2004: 410 with nn. 56–9); also by Dercksen (2005: 112). The snake replacing a broken belt is probably to be seen as a sign of a "great superman", a sort of Hercules-figure using weapons or tools of the most raw and primitive kind — whatever available — to hold his loin-cloth in place, with hardly any other symbolic meaning involved. In a manuscript kindly made available after this was written W. R. Mayer (2006) comes to similar conclusions, explaining ll. 13–19 as "Sargons toller Jagd", in which "wir uns in einer Sagen- und Märchenwelt bewegen". Since a snake occurs in the incantation published by Michel (2004: 410, l. 8, with n. 64) together with a gazelle symbolizing swift and easy delivery, there may, however, be a similar additional point in mentioning both here. Also in *Dumuzi's Dream* 174 ff., cf. *Inanna's Descent* 374 ff., the gazelle and the snake are mentioned as fast animals, in the shape of which Dumuzi seeks to escape his followers. Note also that *šibbu* according to CAD Š/II, 375 indicates both a snake and belt, so the association is easy to make.

3) Günbattı (1997) takes ZA-*ar-a-am* as derived from Sum. zar, which is unlikely because of the *alef*.

4) It is also unlikely that ZA-*ar-a-am* is identical to CAD Z 70 *zarû* A, "pole (of a vehicle, or a part thereof)", attested from OB and recognized as a Sum. loanword, also of a harrow,[48] but unlikely as an etymology in this case because of the *alef*, and because neither *zarû* nor za-ra are typically used in connection with rivers.[49]

17. *libittu* is probably meant as an unbaked "mud brick", in contrast to baked bricks, which are mostly called sig_4-al-ur_5-ra = *agurru*. The point seems to be that Sargon was fast enough to pick up the mud brick before it dissolved, and that the brick was thrown into the water in order to function like an "hourglasss" or "sandclock" that could keep record of the time interval (similarly Dercksen 2005: 117). The missing *-ma* in front of 17: *li-bi*$_4$*-tám* speaks for this solution: both verbs depend on the *-ma* following 16: *áš-ta-kà-an-ma*.

An alternative solution (suggested by J. S. Cooper) is to see the end of l. 13, from *li-bi*$_4$*-tám* through to l. 14 *a-na na-ri-im a-dí-ma* as misplaced, so that this sentence in fact belongs in front of l. 17 *li-bi*$_4$*-tám*. The brick then has nothing directly to do with the gazelle episode, but is only there to illustrate how fast Sargon could dive.

20/26. *ūmišamma*: Cavigneaux (2005: 596) was puzzled by the frequently repeated *-ma*, without finding a clear explanation of its use. There seems to be a clear pattern, however, at least in some cases. In particular in ll. 20, 22, and 26 it certainly denotes emphasis on "every day". It therefore seems significant that *-ma* is not included in l. 24. In ll. 33, 35, 37 and 39 *-ma* is rather to be understood as a sentence connector. A "missing" *-ma* can also be significant, especially that otherwise expected in front of l. 21 (cf. below). Cf. also the comments on l. 17 above.

21–37. Four (or five) qualities of meat are distinguished here: 1) "breast(-meat) (*irtum*, sg. 32; 36, but also *irātum*, pl. 21; 31), probably to be understood as very good meat, but not the very best, approximately "ribsteaks" or "entrecôte". 2) *arkatum* (24), "the long (sc. part of the loin)", approx. "sirloin-steak". This is also very good quality, or even better; 3) *muḫḫum ša kursinātim* (26–7, marrow-of-shanks (cf. below). This is first-class food. 4) *alap(-šu)* UDU(!) *ša-ma-ni-a-am ša ku-sí-i-šu*, "(his) ox (and) eight sheep of his throne", which represent the very best quality meat (34). 5) provided that the reading is justified, *gurnam* "average meat" (37), but read probably *ku-ur-⟨sí-⟩na-am* "shanks", cf. below.

21–9. Unlike previous interpretations the entire section ll. 21–8 is here understood as governed as an object by the verb *iqre* in l. 29, which otherwise would lack an object. It is also significant that there is no *-ma* following l. 20. Besides, it makes good sense stylistically to see the 7000 heroes in l. 21 as recapitulated in l. 30, after a sort of *inclusio*.

21. *irātim*, lit. "(breasts)" sc. meat. The translation "entrecôtes" was suggested by Cavigneaux, but something like "cutlets" or "chops" might make better sense, because these can be made both from the meat of oxen and sheep. J.G.W. translates "brisket", avoiding the problem that "entrecôte" does not mean the same thing in English and French (French: "between the ribs", esp. that cut from between the ninth and eleventh rib, but English: "a boned steak cut off the sirloin"). Van De Mieroop (2000: 151, n. 78) refers to an OA text in private possession, published by V. Donbaz (1990), which lists breast-meat (6 and 9: *i-ìr-tám*

[47] W.R.M. explains: not related to Gilg.: *el-qé-šu-ma aš-ta-ka-an-šu* (36) *a-na a-hi-ia*, "I took it up and put it at my side" (George 2003: 174, col. ii 35–6), which is a normal perfect G in *consecutio temporum*, i.e. prt. followed by *-ma* perfect; differently Dercksen (2005: 112). Metzler (2002: 426) cites ll. 13–18 and analyses the verbal forms as a G-perfect (p. 427). He understands *sar'um* as "Binde" (CAD S 189), as part of sheep used as a bandage (ref. J.G.W.).

[48] This may be etymologically related to Sum. ^{giš}za-ra, "door pivot", cf. e.g. *Lugalbanda Hurrum* 421, quoted by Alster (2005c: 63; same text 341: ma-mú-da ^{giš}ig-e nu-gi_4-e za-ra nu-gi_4-e. Note that in SP 3.37 za-ra dug_4-dug_4 (*muštālu*) is etymologically unrelated, lit. meaning "to you", "don't be inquisitive", cf. Alster (2005a: 116). J. Taylor (2005: 23), however, suggests a different interpretation, based on an unknown noun /zara/, which may be an unnecessary complication.

[49] Gilg. X iii 41 f.; 45; iv 4–8; XI 64; 261, uses *parīsum* (gi-muš, ^{giš}má-rí-za). Cf. also *mašaddu(m)*, used of waggon poles.

ac?) among other meat cuts, 16: *i-k/qí-tám* (= ?), 18: *ki-ša-dam* "necks", 21: *bi-na-num*, but also other types of food, 1: *am-ri-am*, and 7: *kirrum*-bread.

22–4. Note *e-ku-lu-ni*, < **ekkalūni* (GAG § 78 e y) pres.; cf. also *ikkalū* "(die Rinder) fressen (jetzt)" (Fish, *Letters*, 15, 24, now Kraus, ABL 10, 15, ref. J.G.W.).

24. *ar-kà-tim* (*arkātim*) is derived from *arkum* (*arku*), "to be long", cf. Dercksen (2005: 112), so perhaps not "rump(-steak)", as hitherto understood, but rather "sirloin(-steak)". Cavigneaux: "qui mangent les pigots". Foster: "who ate rump-meat". J.G.W. translates "long steaks", cf. her comments below.

26–7. *muḫḫu(m)* is here interpreted as "marrow", but see the possible parallel biblical expression *ḥélāb ḥittim/ḥiṭṭā*, "das 'Fett' von Weizens", cited in the Appendix below. A meaning listed in Wehr, *Dictionary of Arabic* (1961: 896) under *muḫḫ*, pl. *miḫāḫ*, "brain; marrow; medulla; core; essence; purest and choicest part", had previously prompted B.A. to suggest a meaning like "the choicest part" in our case, based on the Arabic cognate *muḫḫ-*, in spite of the time gap. Kerstin Eksell of the Carsten Niebuhr Institute kindly informs us that the meaning "the choicest part" is well attested in Arabic and cannot simply be dismissed as a late development. Cf. W. R. Mayer's, Kerstin Eksell's and Joan Westenholz's comments on *muḫḫum* in the appendix below.

A meaning of *muḫḫu(m)*, "marrow", was first suggested by Stol (2000: 628) and now discussed in detail by Goodnick Westenholz and Sigrist (2006), from whom the following information is excerpted: There is no plain lexical attestation of this meaning, but probably ugu-NI(= dig)-gig corresponded to [*muḫ*?] *qaqqadiy*[*a*] in Larsa Bilingual I of Ugu-mu. ugu-dig(NI) is only attested in the ugu-mu lexical series, apparently meaning "soft cranium", that is "brain". Ebla Vocabulary VE 264 (MEE 4, 228), however, lists SAG × NI = *muḫḫu*, "the *muḫḫu* of the head", "soft part of the head", cf. SAG × NI-SÙ = *mu-ḫu-um* (266c). This is to be kept apart from SAG × NI + ME = *qištum* (*gi-si-tum*) SAG. The Akkadian word *muḫḫu(m)* fails to preserve the Sumerian distinction between ugu, "cranium", and ugu-NI, "brain". The closest possible cognate is *maḫāḫu(m)*, "to soak, to soften".

According to Militarev and Kogan (2000: 169 f., no. 187), the root **muḫḫ*, "brain", is a primary noun found in all Semitic languges, with no known derivation. Cavigneaux (2005) suggests "la moelle(?) des jarrets", commenting on *muḫḫu* (n. 8), "'crâne, haut': on a peut-être ici le sens que le mot a dans les autre langages sémitiques 'cervelle, moelle' (emploi culinaire?)" (suggested independly of Stol 2000).

Since it is unlikely that a large number of soldiers could have eaten marrow alone as a main course, a remark by Goodnick Westenholz and Sigrist may be helpful. They refer to *osso buco* as a "regional dish from the Piedmonte in Italy, in which traditionally a veal shank is used".[50] It consists of entire bones with their meat, cut at a right angle across the long end into round pieces, some 3–4 cms thick each. Yet, since *osso buco* strictly speaking requires a strong saw to cut through the bones, it is less likely to be intended in our case. On the other hand, the biblical parallels mentioned below clearly indicate that marrow was considered a kind of delicacy, so somehow it must have been possible to get to it. Ample archaeological evidence, even back to prehistoric times, indicates that this was done by crushing or splitting the bones (cf. Appendix below with n. 52).

That *muḫḫu(m)* was thought to be a special delicacy connected with bones appears from l. 37: only those parts which there are not expressly said to be qualified as *muḫḫum* (of) shanks are scorched by the cook. J.G.W. further points to biblical, mishnaic, and talmudic references, of which the following two come nearest to the Sargon text: Job 21: 24: "one person dies in the fullness of strength, in all possible happiness and ease, thighs padded with fat and the marrow in the bones good and moist"; Isaiah 25: 6: "The Lord of Hosts will make on this mount for all the peoples a banquet of rich viands, a banquet of choice wines — of rich viands with marrow, of choice wines well-refined" (God provides an extraordinary banquet, with marrow as a special delicacy). In the Job citation, the "marrow in the bones" occurs in the image of prosperity and thus suggests including the verse preceding the one in which marrow occurs.

kursinnu, cf. CAD K 566 A "fetlock of lower leg", is feminine, and the plural *kursinnāte* is well attested, also as a cut of meat, so reading *ku-ur-⟨sí-⟩na-ạm* (sg.) in 37 by a minor error is likely, rather than *gu₅-ur-nu-um*, suggested by Dercksen.

[50] The first sign is almost certainly NISAG, hitherto mostly read DUB(?), followed by DU. Dercksen's (2001) suggests *qištu i-ig-re-e-ma* (*igrē-ma*), of which the first sign requires an emendation to TIR, corrected in Dercksen (2005: 113) to NIR? *du*. This was understood as a reference to *Sargon King of Battle*, II 6a, 66′, cf. also Foster (2005: 73, n. 5). Apart from the emendation problem this is too far away from the "darkness" (*ṣalmum*, l. 42, if so understood, cf. the comments below) to make the alleged connection likely. Better read *iq-re-e-mu* from *qerû* "invited", as already Günbattı has it, with the preceding *i* "my" belonging to the noun, instead of the verb. Hecker (2001: 58) translates "(die ...) lud mein ... ein", considering without much confidence *rēdû*, *rādium* (UKU.UŠ) "Geleiter, Soldat", which is never written as an ideogram in Kültepe.

A suggestion is to read SAG_x(NISAG, here written $MURUB_4$).DU = "he who goes in front" for saŋ.du, tentatively to be understood as *ašarēdu* = *koryphaios andrí*, here probably meant as a military leader, like "captain". This understanding is likely in view of the context, in which the term is opposed to the "last man" (ll. 32;

This dish is prepared with spices and vegetables, such as "osso buco con piselli e funghi". Other authorities say it comes from Lombardia, though. Artusi writes enthusiastically about it in his *Arte di mangiar bene* (1973), but says nothing about its origin. Alibab's cooking book (1944 or earlier) mentions it as a French dish, which, by the way, is also known in Italy! (refs. courtesy N. W. Bruun).

35). The sign MURUB$_4$ can hardly be *šakkanakku* "governor" here, but rather has the reading sag$_x$. The reading sag$_x$ for UD-*gunû* or similar has been discussed by J. van Dijk (1965: 19 ff.), noting that nisag etymologically is *níŋ-saŋ, so that in itself it means something of first or best quality. According to Civil (1987: 35), nisag correctly written has an unbroken vertical at the end. It thus differs from MURUB$_4$, which has a broken vertical at the end and is one of the ancestors of ŠID, but the two signs are sometimes conflated: LAK 159 is used until Ur III. Since our sign has a broken vertical at the end, the identification with MURUB$_4$ and the reading remain doubtful.

No examples of saŋ$_x$.du or saŋ.du as an ideogram in Old Assyrian are known, where only SAG ITU.KAM, SAG *ku-ṣi-im* or SAG.BA would be the closest possible parallels (refs. G.B.), but it seems likely that our scribe had saŋ.du in mind, and just used a slightly irregular sign for it, especially since NISAG may have been more familiar from more frequent use in Old Sumerian or Old Akkadian. How precisely this was thought to be rendered in our text is uncertain, but the literal translation of the Sumerian term, "he who goes in front", makes good sense, and was perhaps understood as such here. The point may be that the "guests", or maybe "everyone", that is, all groups of soldier, were not invited by Sargon himself, but by one of his officials.

J.G.W. accepts the interpretation as *ašarēdu* and points out that parallels occur in the Sargonic literary material, meaning "champion": *Sargon the Conquering Hero* 10, written *a-ša-re-du-um*, see Goodnick Westenholz (1997: 62), and (with a minor emendation) *Sargon King of Battle* 7, written *a-ša-⟨ri⟩-id* LUGAL.G[I ...] (ibid. p. 110). None of these references have the sign-combination of our text.

32. *ana warkîm*, "the last man", so Dercksen (2005: 113). Note that this is here used as a collective singular, therefore rather the "rear party", because an ox and eight sheep would be too much for a single man. See also J. Goodnick Westenholz's comments below.

34. Since *ku-ša-ma-ni-a-am* does not seem to make sense, a simple solution is to read the first sign KU with a minute emendation to UDU, which is also suggested by the parallelism with the preceding nearly identical pairs. Note that, unlike ll. 38–9 etc., there is no plural marker ḪI.A here, because the number was in fact limited to one, or specified as precisely eight. Similarly, there is no conjunction *ù* here, although it might have been expected in front of l. 34. Is some misunderstanding involved, since UDU = *immerum* "sheep", reminds us of *imēr* (*kussîm*), a "donkey" used for hauling a chair? (cf. the references provided by Dercksen 2005: 113). Dercksen (ibid.) reads *ku-ša-ma-ni-a-am*, "from Kušamman", but states that a toponym *Kušammān* is otherwise unknown; cf. n. 12 above.

ša ku-sí-i-šu: This is not the idiom *bīt kussî*, "royal property (real estate)", cf. CAD K 593, attested in OAkk and LB, because *-šu* would be unaccounted for, and it clearly relates to the "captain" in l. 29. Instead it can be understood as a throne on which a ruler sat (cf. Dercksen, just quoted). Cavigneaux: "son bœuf ... de son siège (sa selle?)" (i.e. saddle).

ša-ma-ni-a-am is derived from *samāne* "eight", Ass. *šamāne*.

37. Reading *gu$_5$-ur-na-am* = *gurnum* was suggested by Dercksen (2005: 113), who translates "meat of mediocre quality". Cf., however, AHw "Durchschnittsqualität"; CAD adj. "of average quality", said of garments, oil, dates, and beer, but not typically of meat. The reading proposed by previous editors *ku-ur-⟨sí-⟩na-am* (sg.) in parallelism with l. 27 (pl.) is therefore more convincing.

42. *i-na i-ki-il$_5$-tim* can be taken as *ikiltum*, "darkness" derived from *ekēlu(m)*, "to be dark", or derived from *akālum*, as first suggested by Hecker ("beim Essen"), but consided less likely by Dercksen (2001 and 2005: 113) and Cavigneaux (2005: 599, n. 10). Dercksen refers to Kt n/k 520: 36 *i-na i-ki-il$_5$-tí ēnēšunu*, in the following context: (35) *i-nu-mi mì-ší-iḫ-tim* (36) *i-na i-ki-il$_5$-tí e-né-šu-nu* / SÍG.ḪI.A (37) *ba-lúm sà-nu-qí-im i-na* (38) É-*tí-a i-dí-ú-ma ù* (39) *im-ta-áš-ḫu*, which Dercksen translates "But at the time of the robbery, they, in their stupidity (lit.: "in the darkness of their eyes"), deposited wool in my house without checking (its weight), and (robbers) have now snatched (it) away!" Darkness fits better than greediness here, because the robbers were different from those who deposited the wool.

In our text darkness seems to relate to a theme in the omen literature. Cavigneaux (2005: 599, n. 13) points to Schileico (1928–9) 215, l. 8: *ša iklitam iḫbutuma nūram īmuru*, an omen of Sargon. The theme is also represented in a number of omens, according to which darkness befell Sargon campaigning in Marhaši in Iran, Goetze (1947: 255–6), and in two compositions about Sargon, see J. Goodnick Westenholz (1997), esp. p. 69 ad *Sargon the Conquering Hero* ll. 57–64; 71 and 91; cf. also Dercksen (2005: 113).

43. For *um-mi-ni-a*, Van De Mieroop's (2000: 151) suggestion: "mes créanciers" is now obsolete. Foster's suggestion "I sat with my troops in darkness", with comments (2005: 73, n. 7): "Wordplay on 'troops' (*ummânu*) and 'creditors' (*ummiānū*)", is not convincing, because *ummānum*, "troops", is not contracted. Cavigneaux: "je restai dans l'obscurité avec mon ministre (?)", commenting, p. 599, that "with my troops" would require **um-ma-ni-a*, but that, anyway, "il faut corriger *um-mè*[N.B. misprint for *me*]⟨*-a*⟩*-ni-a*", since there is no contraction in OA. "Troops" undoubtedly makes best sense here. A.W. instead suggests a dialectal form **ummanum* with short *-a-* (cf. *awātum*), which would yield *ummīnīya* (ME then = *mì*). Similarly also W.R.M., who compares **ramanum*, Bab. *ramānum*.

44–5. The combination of ^{na_4}GUG (= *sāmtu*) "carnelian" and ^{na_4}za-gìn (= *uqnû*) "lapis lazuli" is attested elsewhere, cf. SP 2.45: dumu um-mi-a ^{na_4}gug-gim ti-ba un-bùr e-ne dub-sar-ra-àm; ti-ba un-bùr ^{na_4}na-za-gìn-na-àm, "the schoolmaster's pupil (is) carnelian whose side has been pierced: he is indeed a scribe. It's only after its side has been pierced that it is (truly) lapis lazuli". This makes it clear that such stones were

considered as having their true value mainly after they had been pierced with a hole through which they could be attached to something else, in our case a symbol of the king's power.

In l. 45 our *qanû* is well attested in OA, written *qà-nu-e* or *qá-nu-we*. It here undoubtedly represents Sumerian GI "reed", "staff" or "rod", which often (but not expressly here) occurs with the "ring" (ÉŠ). Apparently the precious stones are meant as attached (*rakāsu* "bind") to the rod as embellishment. Foster (2005: 75, n. *) refers to CAD Q 87b, *qanû* denoting a package of reeds. Here *qanû* is probably best understood as a measuring rod symbolizing Sargon's sovereignty over the land, because it is embellished with lapis lazuli (*qanuam ša sāmtim u uqnîm*), as is Inanna's measuring rod in *Inanna's Descent* 25: gi 1 ninda éš-gána ba-gin šu ba-ni-in-du$_8$.

Hallo (2005: 159–61) explains that the staff is usually designated šíbir or the like (often as a pair eškiri "staff and nose-rope") = *šibirru*, "staff". Both the staff and the "nose-rope and, for good measure, the sceptre, were bestowed on the king ..." (p. 151), but "the nose-rope was so regularly attached to the ring (and perhaps sometimes to the staff as well) that it gave its name to both". Hallo does not accept the usual understanding of the rod and nose-rope as measuring tools, and explains them as royal rather than divine insignia (p. 161). The symbolism evidently originates in tools with which to control cattle. This differs from what is often viewed as a sceptre. For a discussion of the concept of sceptre as a royal emblem in Mesopotamia see Suter (2000: 291 f.).

47. *ú-za-iz*: The rod is presumably seen as a unit of several reeds that can be divided, and it was the authority symbolized by the rod that was meant to be "distributed" to the land. Foster (2005: 73, with n. 8), translates "I made a package of carnelian and lapis, verily I made a distribution to the land", but admits that "the passage is not clear" and further explains that "either Sargon distributed the left-over food or some precious stones at court to the land". Cf. Van De Mieroop (2000: 151): "a symbolic act for which I can find no parallel".

48. From *amḫaṣ + šu = amḫassūma. ḫu-ma-nam:* The identification of Ḫumānum with the Amanus mountains is questioned by Dercksen (2005: 113).[51] Foster (2005: 74, n. 1) sees *am-ḫa-sú-ma* as an implicit wordplay, as the verb can both be used of "beating" an enemy and of "hammering down" a peg, but in the next line the statue is erected rather than "hammered down". It is relevant, however, that *sikkatam maḫāṣum* is used as a legal phrase in juridical texts regarding the symbolic step of taking possession of real estate (so J. G. W.). See also Dercksen (2005: 114), who points out that in OA *maḫāṣum* means "to divide into x parts".

49. *sí-ki-tim*: derived from CAD S 247 *sikkatu* A "peg", etc.

51. For Tukriš and Ḫutura, see Van De Mieroop (2000: 152) with previous literature.

52. As seen by Foster (2005: 75, n. *) and Cavigneaux (2005: 600, with n. 15), both with further previous literature, our *bi$_4$-bi$_4$-na-tim* is related to *bibi(n)nu*, also mentioned in an inscription of Naramsin (Brockmon Tablet 1, Frayne, RIME 2.1.4.6 ii 4′): *bí-bí-in-na-at-sú-nu ugallib*. Since in the *Great Rebellion* i 16 (cf. Goodnick Westenholz 1997: 230–57), Sargon is said to have shaved (*galābum*) and cut off the *bibinātum* of the people of Kish, but nevertheless they revolted against Naramsin, it is likely to be a slavemark, also for women, or a kind of hairdressing or similar that could be removed. Hecker (2001: 59, n. 52a) considers "Nasenflügel?". Westenholz (1999: 24 and 42) points out that the revolt against Sargon's "son" Naramsin in later tradition was conceived as ingratitude, because on the whole the Sargonic dynasty was remembered in a positive attitude, although not all contemporary Akkadians may have shared that view.

56. For *a-mu-re-e*, rather than *-ri-e*, see Hecker, GKT § 17 G: "in den obliquen Kasus des Pl. und in den Adverbialendung besteht eine leichte Vorliebe für ē ....". Similarly 57 *ki-lá-re-e*; 61: *lu-ùḫ-me-e*.

57. Cavigneaux (2005: 601) rejects Van De Mieroop's translation "Those of Amurru ... I finished" on grounds that *qatû* is intransitive, but refrains from suggesting an alternative translation. It is in fact possible to understand it as an intransitive verb "I was finished (sc. dragging the scarves as tightly as possible)" albeit with some ellipsis of meaning. The point might then be that the Amorites were squeezed within clothes pulled as tightly as if to be branded with a mark on their noses, from *šamātu(m)*, "to brand". A more likely solution is, however that *qatû* is here used transitive, since its cognates in Aramaic and West-Semitic *qatû* or *qaṭû* mean "to cut", not "to come to an end", as already suggested by Stol in Hecker (2001: 59, n. 59a). A difficulty remains, however, in that *šamāṭu* is not otherwise used of removing body parts (*nakāsum* would be expected instead), cf. CAD Š/I 308 f. *šamāṭu*, "to strip off, tear lose, cut off", said about dates, metal or wood, etc.; AHw 1155 I "losreißen".

ša-ar-šu-nu can be taken as *išaru* "penis", which is more convincing than *išru*, "scarf?", here, but note that it is singular. Cavigneaux (2005: 601 with n. 18), however, prefers *išru*, "scarf?". Hecker (2001: 59, n. 59a) "Gemeint ist wohl ... ihnen bis auf den letzten Mann statt der Nase den Penis abschnitt". For *kīma* meaning "instead of", see AHw *kīma* A 8 d, and for OA Hecker, GKT § 127 f. *a-pì* is best derived from *appum* "nose".

Kilari: a geographical location, cf. Van De Mieroop (2000: 152, n. 94), also attested in ICK 1, 174: *ana kilarium*; p/k 5+6 (unpubl): 1 *am-tam ki-lá-ri-tám*, apparently not far from Kaneš (refs. G.B.).

The translation "reins" for *i(n) maršim* was suggested by G. Barjamovic, who points out that *maršum* is very common in OA texts, meaning rein or bands with which to bind moneybags, or sandals with long

[51] Therefore Foster's (2005: 74, n. 1) reference to A. George (1990) is less relevant. Cf. n. 28 above.

laces (cf. CAD M 296). An illustration can be found in a third-millennium female statuette from Hasanoğlan near Ankara; see E. Akurgal (1961: pl. VIII, 64) (ref. J.G.W.).

59. Most commentators emend to *kà-ni-ší-⟨e⟩*, but *kà-ni-ší-⟨am⟩* (*kanišīam*, cf. 53 *alašīam*) may be suggested instead.

59. *ša-ni-um*: Foster (2005: 74), translating "once again", is undoubtedly right in deriving this from a numeral like "two", cf. CAD Š/I 387 *šanītam*, adv. "another time", attested in OB, Mari, etc. The *-um* ending seems here to be used adverbially, like the Sum. min-kam-ma-šè. Since it is not obvious what the first time could have been, it may here mean "besides", "in addition" or similar, although no parallels in OA have so far been found. Already Hecker (2001: 59, n. 59a) considers *ša-ni-um ša kà-ni-ší-⟨e⟩*, but comments "würde zu der wenig überzeugenden Übersetzung 'ein anderer ließ die ... Kaneschiter los' führen".

60. *ú-šé-er* can be from *wuššuru*, so Foster (2005: 74) "released", which is also used in the sense "make (something) free to be sold". Cavigneaux (2005: 598): "entouré/relâche", in addition to *wuššuru*, suggests another possibility, but without explaining it further. Some OA examples are n/k 1637 (unpubl.) ANŠE.ḪI.A *ù* URUDU *ú-šé-ér-ni-a-tí*; CCT 5, 44b: *amala* 2 *ūmēšu, kārum ṣāḫer rabi ú-šé-er-šu* (refs. G.B.).

ZU-DU-*ḫi-šu-nu* (= *sú-tù-ḫi-šu-nu* from *sutuḫḫu*?) so far remains unexplained. Already Günbattı and Hecker (2001: 59, n. 60a) refer to the hapax *šutuḫḫu* (CAD Š/III p. 411a) which builds a fem. pl., and is only attested in an OAkk letter (OAIC 52: 6), read by Gelb: "Why do you withhold bread for(?) the troop — you request *šutuḫḫu* or *kismarri*", in unclear context.

61. *ša ḫa-tim*: In later texts Ḫattum refers to the Hittites. For OA see Van De Mieroop (2000: 153).

lu-ùḫ-me-e: A mountain people, perhaps attested in Hittite texts, cf. Van De Mieroop (2000: 153).

62. As a literal translation W.R.M. suggests "ich machte die Gewandnadel spitz, die gutäische — in Bezug auf(?) die L.," which perhaps allows the paraphrased translation suggested here.

tù-dí-tám: AHw 1365 *tudittu* "ein Brustschmuck für Frauen", is derived from Sum. tu-di-da, typically used of Inanna's jewellery. For the meaning *tudittum* = "toggle-pin" see H. Klein (1983: 255–84); Farber (1987: 96–8).

ú-di-id is D *uddudu* from *edēdu* "to be/become pointed", D therefore "to make pointed" (CAD D 24). *qú-tí-tám* is derived from CAD Q 328 *qutû* (adj.) "Gutian".

Foster connects *tù-dí-tám* with *ku-dí-tám* and translates "Gutian togglepin". Cavigneaux takes *ku-dí-tám* as independent, "les Goutiennes" (fem.), which is less convincing. Probably some pun is involved, cf. Foster (2005: 74, n. 5), who comments "perhaps the Gutians ... were 'a thorn in the side of' the Luhmeans", but considers the reference obscure.

lu-lu-am probably refers to Lullu(bu), northeast of Assyria, cf. Foster (2005: 74, n. 6).

For Ḫaḫḫum cf. n. 32 above.

Hecker (2001: 59) convincingly reads *ṣú*[!]*-ba*[!]*-ti-šu-nu* from the copy (photo illegible). Dercksen (2005: 115) states that "according to the photo the sign IM is written below *ri*, not below *ú-ša*, indicated by the copy. Hence the verbal form is *ušarrim*, not *ušāri* as previously thought" (or *ušarri*?). He translates "I slit open their clothes". If this is correct (unfortunately the photograph is virtually illegible at this point), it also affects l. 63, which can no longer be read *i-ṭup-pí-im*, but must be *i-ṭup-pè* "on (other) tablets". This affects whether the focus is on Sargon or the scribe, cf. the comments on l. 63. The verb *šarāmu*(*m*) in D means "to trim, to cut to size" (cf. CAD Š/II 49), not "to slit open", so the reading, if correct, does not clearly solve any problem. Since it is most unlikely that this tablet, being a complete unit in itself, would end with a reference to "other tablets", we still prefer to understand IM as belonging to l. 63.

ú-ša-ri: Reading a form of *šarû* "to make sumptuous", in l. 62 causes an anacoluthon, since some kind humiliation is expected, but it nevertheless makes good sense as the thriving of Ḫaḫḫum as a result of textile trade, so this reading is preferred here. Van De Mieroop (2000: 154) hesitatingly: "I made rich". Cavigneaux 62: "j'ai fait bouffler (?) leurs habits". Foster 62: "I made the garments of Lulua and Hahhu sumptuous". All derive from *šarû*. Similarly Hecker (2001: 59, n. 62a) tentatively translates "machte ich mit ihren Gewändern reich", leaving open possibilities other than *šarû* D.

63. There is no agreement on the initial numeral. The copy shows perhaps 10+three verticals. Hecker (2001: 58) reads "4[!]". Van De Mieroop (2000: 154, n. 105) considers the reading 13 senseless and understands the line as referring to "the three posts of heaven", which, however, is hardly more convincing. The first signs may be read *sí-ki*. This could be *sikku*, which is well attested in OA, meaning "hem" or "fringe", but only said about garments. Could it perhaps mean the line where the sky meets mountains? If read *zi-qí*, it could be CAD Z 128 *ziqqu* "crest, edge, battlement", cf. esp. the somewhat similar OB ref. cited there *elênum zi-iq-qú-šu lišnunū šamā'i* "above, its (the temple's) battlements (or tops) rival the sky (in height)". The best explanation may simply be that Sargon touched a number of mountain tops during his campaigns. In later tradition Sargon was remembered for having travelled widely, and future kings were exhorted to imitate him. This would then be a first attestation of a theme much later elaborated in the *Alexander Romance*, in which Alexander is said to have explored the whole world by going to its extreme ends. Dercksen (2005: 115–16), following a suggestion by W. Van Soldt, understands this as possibly referring to the "three stellar paths known from the Middle Babylonian period onwards", which is less convincing here, where such a concept would seem too "technical" and probably anachronistic. It is more likely that it conveys ideas similar to the so-called Babylonian *Mappa Mundi* (CT 22, 48), for which see Horowitz (1988) with an addition by Horowitz (1997). J.G.W. also points out that the theme occurs in *Sargon's Birth Legend*, l. 20: [*a-n*]*a* BÀD AN.KI GAL-*i*

[...] *lu-u* [...], "The Great Wall of Heaven and Earth(?), I did ascend" (so A; B: [...] .KI.GAL-*i* [...] (Goodnick Westenholz 1997: 42), cf. also ibid. p. 44, l. 30: [...] BÀD AN.KI GAL-*i li-li-ma*, "Let him ascend to the Great Wall of Heaven and Earth(?)!".

63. Cavigneaux's (2005: 596) translation is quoted in the introduction above. The speaker may be Sargon, although Cavigneaux's translation makes one think of the scribe who wrote the present tablet.

64. *a-nu-um* has hitherto by all commentators been taken as the god Anu, but Cavigneaux (2005: 601) derives it from *a-nu-um* = *annum* < *arnum* "faute, châtiment", which would explain the following subjunctives. This is doubtful, however, since l. 38 writes *ar-ni-šu* unassimilated. He takes the subject of 64 (*i-de*$_8$*-a-ni*) as the implicit 3rd pers pl. fem. in *nišū* "les gens". A.W., however, suggests an emendation to ⟨*a-*⟩*a-nu-um* (*ayyānum*) instead of *a-nu-um*, "where do they not know me, that I am the king!", also pointing out that in Cavigneaux's translation a *ša* would probably be required before *lá i-tí-a-ni* (*i-de*$_8$*-a-ni*). W.R.M. also questions *nišū* = "they" in ll. 64–5, and alternatively tentatively suggests, without emendation, "Anum hat mich nicht im Stich gelassen" (/*iddianni*/ from *nadûm*), which is preferred here because it requires no emendation. Cf. CAD N/1 78–9, *nadû* 1 c.

65–6. The last two signs in 65: ^{d}*adad* LUGAL are written so that they seem to belong to l. 65 rather than 66. Dercksen (2005: 110) places them at the end of 66.

66. Hecker (2001: 60, n. 65a) notes the Babylonian form *lišarbiū* instead of Ass. *lušarbiū*. Also *ša-tù-uk-ki* written with doubling of the consonant is atypical of OA. Dercksen (2005: 110): *ša-tù-uk-ki*, "the regular offerings to me", but Van De Mieroop "make my offering abundant"; similarly Hecker. The latter is to be preferred, since *ša-tù-uk-ki* can be understood as: 1) *šattukkī* (pl.) without "mine" (OA *-ē*), or 2) *šattukkī* (sg.) with "mine". Wilcke, in Schwemer (2001: 134) suggest reading *ša tukkī* in the beginning of 66 and translates 64–6: "Kennt Anum mich nicht (sowieso)? (Weiß er nicht,) daß ich der König bin, daß ich das obere und untere Land erobert habe, auf daß der König Adad meinen Ruhm groß sein lasse?". Cf. AHw 1367, *tukku*, "Alarmsignal; Bedrückung".

Cavigneaux (2005: 601) comments that this is addressed to the readers/listeners rather than to the gods, and observes that a normal royal inscription would end with a curse formula at this point. The autobiographical *narû*-format, however, is likely to explain why the text does not follow the normal pattern of royal inscriptions in every instance.

Appendix on muḫḫum *"marrow" (l. 26) and the crushing of bones*

W. R. Mayer has kindly commented on the meaning of *muḫḫu(m)* and checked its cognates in other Semitic languages. He provides the following information:

> *muḫḫum* im Sinne "reinster und bester Teil"? Vergleiche im Hebräischen *ḥéläb ḥiṭṭīm/ḥiṭṭā* "Das 'Fett' des Weizens".
> Die Quelle für Wehrs Wiedergabe ist wohl al-Qāmūs. Denn in unserem ältesten Lexikon hier [the Pontifical Biblical Institute in Rome, B.A.] dem von Freitag, IV (1837), heißt es: *medulla; adeps oculi; purior meliorque pars rei. Kam.* — von hier haben alle Späteren abgeschrieben.
> Syrisch: "Hirn, Mark, Eigelb, ..." (Brockelmann 397b).
> Jüdisch-babylonisch Aramäisch: idem (Sokoloff 647).
> Hoftijzer-Jongeling, DNWSI 610: aramäisch: nichts; phönizisch: *mḥ* vielleicht "Fett", *mḥ* Adj. "fett, reich".
> Meiner Ansicht nach ist eher das hebräische "Fett des Weizens" eine Parallele.

J. Goodnick Westenholz comments that the word *ḥéläb* in the metaphorical expression the "choicest part" is short for *ḥéläb kelayiot* "fat of kidneys", see Deut. 32:14, where the complete expression occurs: "Curd of kine, milk of sheep, with fat of lambs, and rams of the breed of Bashan, and he-goats, with the kidney-fat of wheat ..."

Kerstin Eksell of the Carsten Niebuhr Institute has kindly checked the meaning listed in Wehr, *Dictionary of... Arabic* (1961: 896) under *muḫḫ*, pl. *miḫāḫ*, "brain; marrow; medulla; core; essence; purest and choicest part". It is attested in Edward Lane's lexicon, which cites it under the abbreviation "A". This refers to the Arabic grammarians used by Lane, in this case "Asas" of al-Zamaḫšari. These do not expressly date their references, but since they wrote between ca. 100 after Muhammed's death and AD 1700, the meaning "the best, the purest part" goes back to at least AD 1700, so it cannot simply be dismissed as a late development in Arabic (the individual quotations have not been checked, however). Also *Arabic-English Lexicon*, ed. Stanley-Poole (London and Edinburgh 1885) s.v. *muḫḫun*, cites a number of examples, marked "A", meaning "the purest or best".

There is ample archaeological evidence for the crushing or splitting of bones of animals in order to get access to the marrow, even back to prehistoric times. Thus, the oldest traces of human settlement in Denmark are some bones from a complete skeleton of fallow deer found near

Hollerup, Jutland. These were crushed by human hands, presumably by Neandertals, in the interglacial period about 125,000 years ago.[52]

The following reference to *muḫḫum* came too late to be incorporated above: no. 34 in Durand (2006) 27: *ištu anāku muḫḫam amazzaqu šū kursinātim linakkis* (A. 111: 29), "Once I have sucked the marrow, he will cut the shanks". Durand translates, "Une fois que j'aurais sucé la cervelle, qu'il découpe les paturons!", commenting "cela revient évidemment à dire: 'Pour moi la meilleurs part, pour lui la plus mauvaise'." Rather than an expression of who obtains the best part, he sees this as "une manigance politique où la ruse est plus présente que la force". Here *muḫḫum* clearly means "marrow".

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[52] This sensational discovery was published by U. Møhl (1956). A fine photograph is shown in Jørgen Jensen (2001: 23). [For an example closer in time and space see J. A Weber's contribution in Part VI of the report on the Tell Brak excavations in the volume. Eds.]

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